

Haligric Research Integration Series

AKAN TRADITION

Ghana and Ivory Coast

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

Beliefs, Rituals, and Traditions of the Akan Peoples — Nyame, the Adinkra, the Golden Stool, and the Living Philosophy of Sankofa

The Sankofa bird looks backward while moving forward.

It is not wrong to go back and fetch what you forgot.

The Kra — divine spark given by God at birth — is indestructible.

*The Adinkra symbols are a living philosophical language:
every form a teaching, every teaching alive.*

The Asante Kingdom has never surrendered its Golden Stool.

The ancestors are still drinking the libation.

Sankofa. Go back and fetch it.

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Introduction

Among the many rich philosophical and spiritual traditions of West Africa, the Akan tradition of present-day Ghana and Ivory Coast holds a distinctive position: it is simultaneously one of the most complete in terms of its philosophical sophistication, one of the most visually expressive in terms of its sacred art forms, and one of the most directly accessible to practitioners outside the tradition through the worldwide recognition of the Adinkra symbols and the Sankofa concept.

The Akan are not a single ethnic group but a family of related peoples — the Asante (Ashanti), the Fante, the Akuapem, the Akyem, the Denkyira, the Bono, and others — who share a common language family (the Twi/Akan languages), a common cosmological framework, and a common set of cultural institutions including the matrilineal clan system, the stool as sacred authority, and the Adinkra symbol tradition.

For Haligricity, the Akan tradition offers three specific and irreplaceable gifts: a soul anatomy (Kra/Sunsum/Mogya/Ntoro) that is among the most complete and most philosophically precise in any tradition; the Adinkra symbol system as a living visual philosophy in which every form is a teaching; and the Sankofa principle — perhaps the most Haligric concept in any tradition anywhere — the teaching that looking backward to reclaim what was lost is not regression but wisdom.

Who the Akan Are

History, Geography, and Culture

The Akan peoples inhabit the southern and central portions of present-day Ghana and the eastern portions of Ivory Coast — a region of tropical forest, coastal savanna, and rich agricultural land that has been one of the most productive and most politically sophisticated areas of West Africa for over a millennium.

The Asante Kingdom

The most historically prominent Akan state was the Asante (Ashanti) Kingdom, founded in the late 17th century by Osei Tutu under the guidance of the priest Okomfo Anokye, who called down from heaven the Golden Stool (Sika Dwa Kofi) — the sacred throne that became the symbol of the Asante nation's soul and unity. The Asante resisted British colonial conquest with extraordinary tenacity — fighting five wars against the British Empire before being finally subjugated in 1900 after the War of the Golden Stool. Yaa Asantewaa, the queen mother of Ejisu, led the armed uprising, declaring: "If you, men, will not go forward, then we will. We, the women, will. I shall call upon my fellow women. We will fight the white men until the last of us falls in the battlefield."

Matrilineal Descent — The Akan Family System

The Akan peoples practice matrilineal descent — inheritance, clan membership, and succession pass through the mother's line rather than the father's. This is not merely a social arrangement but a theological one: the blood (mogya) flows through the mother, while the sunsum (spirit and character) comes from the father. There are eight principal Akan matrilineal clans: Asona, Agona, Aduana, Oyoko, Asene, Biretuo, Ekuona, and Asakyiri. Clan membership is exogamous — one may not marry within one's clan.

Akan Cosmology

Nyame, Asase Yaa, and the Sacred Order

Akan cosmology begins with Nyame — the supreme being, the omnipotent, omniscient, eternal creator who is the source of all existence. Nyame is known by many names: Onyankopon ("the Greater Nyame"), Odomankoma ("the infinite inventor"), and Brekyirihunuade ("the Almighty"). In the most famous Akan myth, Nyame once dwelt close to humanity — an old woman pounding fufu kept striking the sky with her pestle until Nyame, offended, rose far out of reach. He became a *deus otiosus* — a withdrawn god — and his distance is precisely why the Abosom and the ancestors matter: they are the accessible faces of a creator who has stepped back into the heights.

Asase Yaa — The Earth Goddess

Asase Yaa is the second most important sacred power in the Akan universe — the great female spirit of the earth, wife of Nyame, and mother of the dead. "Yaa" means she was born on Thursday — the Akan believe Nyame created the earth on Thursday — and farmers refrain from tilling on Thursdays in her honor. She holds no temples and no formal priesthood — you are always standing on her, which is reverence enough. Her name is called immediately after Nyame's in every libation. She governs the gateway to Asamando — the Akan ancestral realm — and receives the dead back into her womb. Her title Aberewaa means "Old Woman" — the ancient one who receives all who come at the end.

The Wider Cosmology

Nyame and Asase Yaa together gave birth to four primary Abosom: Bia (river deity of the Bia River), Epo (spirit of the sea), Bosomtwe (spirit of Lake Bosomtwe — Ghana's only natural lake), and Tano (the river god of justice, water, and storms). The Mmoatia are small dwarf-like forest spirits — dangerous and wise — known to take human beings into the forest for years, returning them with deep herbal knowledge. The Sasabonsam are terrifying forest giants who represent the forest's dangerous and unpredictable dimension.

The Soul Anatomy

Kra, Sunsum, Mogya, and Ntoro

The Akan understanding of the human being's spiritual composition is one of the most sophisticated soul anatomies in any tradition.

KRA: The divine spark given by Nyame at birth — the life force itself. It returns to Nyame at death.

SUNSUM: The personal spirit — the dimension expressing individual character, personality, and life force. The Sunsum is the part of you others feel when you enter a room.

MOGYA: The blood inherited through the mother's lineage. Mogya determines clan membership (abusua) — the social-spiritual fabric of Akan life.

NTORO: The spiritual essence transmitted through the father — character, temperament, and specific sacred qualities. Each Ntoro group has specific taboos and personality characteristics.

The Kra in Detail

The Divine Spark at Birth

The Kra is the most sacred dimension of the human being in Akan theology — the divine spark Nyame places within each person at birth. Before incarnation, the Kra kneels before Nyame and receives its specific destiny (nkrabea) — the life path, challenges, gifts, and purpose for this incarnation. The day of the week on which a person is born is their Kra day (Krada): Kwasi/Akosua (Sunday), Kwadwo/Adwoa (Monday), Kwabena/Abena (Tuesday), Kwaku/Akua (Wednesday), Yaw/Yaa (Thursday), Kofi/Afia (Friday), Kwame/Ama (Saturday).

Kra Washing — Personal Practice

PURPOSE: To cleanse, strengthen, and honor the innermost divine spark on your birth day or at any time of significant transition.

WHAT YOU NEED: White clay (kaolin/hyire), a fresh egg, cool clean water, white fabric.

STEP 1: On your birth day of the week (or the new moon), prepare a quiet space with white fabric spread out.

STEP 2: Mix the white clay with cool water to make a thin paste.

STEP 3: Hold the egg in both hands. The egg represents the potential of the Kra that has not yet been expressed.

STEP 4: Roll the egg gently over your body from head to feet — slowly, with intention, drawing out any accumulated spiritual debris.

STEP 5: Apply white clay to your forehead, palms, and soles. Speak: "Nyame, I honor the Kra you placed within me. I cleanse and strengthen it. May I walk in alignment with the destiny you gave me."

STEP 6: Sit quietly for fifteen minutes. Then wash off the clay with cool water.

STEP 7: Dispose of the egg in nature — not eaten. It has absorbed what needed to be released.

The Sunsum

The Personal Spirit and Character

The Sunsum is the personal spirit — the dimension of the human being that expresses individual character, personality, and life force in the world. It is what makes each individual specifically themselves — the quality of their presence, the specific character others encounter.

The Sunsum can become ill — through spiritual attack, violation of sacred taboos, excessive grief or trauma, or prolonged moral failure. Symptoms include social withdrawal, diminished effectiveness, unexplained illness, and a general sense of spiritual depletion. Treatment is the work of an Okomfo who diagnoses the spiritual cause and performs ceremonies to cleanse, strengthen, and restore the Sunsum.

Destiny, Free Will, and the Akan Understanding of Fate

The Akan understanding of the relationship between destiny (nkrabea) and free will is among the most nuanced in any tradition. Nkrabea is the destiny received from Nyame before birth — the life template that includes specific gifts, challenges, relationships, and purpose. It is not fixed mechanical fate — it is a territory with a specific character that the person navigates through their choices.

Obra (character, the lived life) is what the person makes of their nkrabea through their choices. "When you follow in the path of your father, you learn to walk like him" — what you inherit shapes what you do, but you are not your inheritance. You are what you do with it.

Nyame

The Akan Understanding of God

Nyame is not merely the supreme being in a pantheon — Nyame is the ultimate reality, the source of all existence. Nyame is omnipotent, omniscient, omnipresent — qualities the Akan explicitly attribute. Unlike the Yoruba Olodumare (too remote for direct approach), Nyame is understood as directly accessible. Akan people pray to Nyame directly — in crisis, in gratitude, in daily life.

The Nyame dua (God's tree) is the primary physical symbol of Nyame's presence — a forked stick planted near the entrance to the home, with a clay pot in the fork containing water, herbs, and sacred materials, regularly refreshed as an ongoing acknowledgment of divine presence.

Asase Yaa

The Earth Goddess

Asase Yaa is the second most important sacred power in the Akan universe — the great female spirit of the earth, wife of Nyame, and mother of all the dead. She is the earth's personification: fertile, ancient, and inescapable. The Akan regard the earth as female because of its capacity to bring forth life.

Asase Yaa holds no temples and no formal priesthood — you are always standing on her, which is reverence enough. Her name is called immediately after Nyame's in every libation — she is the first to receive the offering because it is through the earth that the ancestors are reached. She governs Asamando — the Akan ancestral realm — and receives the dead back into her womb. Her title Aberewaa means "Old Woman" — the ancient one who receives all who come at the end.

Thursday is her sacred day — farmers traditionally refrain from tilling in her honor. Asase Yaa is also the Goddess of Truth: she cannot be deceived. The Mmoatia — the small forest dwarf-spirits — are her servants and the guardians of the deep forest.

The Abosom

Akan Spiritual Forces

The Abosom (singular: obosom) are the spiritual forces of the Akan tradition — beings of significant sacred power who inhabit specific natural features and serve as intermediaries between the human community and Nyame. The major rivers of the Akan heartland — the Tano River, the Pra River, the Birim River — each house specific Abosom whose power governs the fertility of the land and the health of the communities along their banks.

The Okomfo is the Akan spiritual practitioner who serves as the primary vehicle for the Abosom's communication with the human community — a medium/priest chosen by a specific Obosom through experiences of illness, dreams, or involuntary possession, then trained by senior practitioners.

The Ancestors (Nsamanfo) in Akan Life

The ancestors (Nsamanfo) are active, present, and influential participants in Akan life. They are not remote historical figures — they are the extended community, present in the life of the living family, concerned with its welfare, capable of blessing and of withholding blessing.

The ancestor tradition flows through the matrilineal clan (abusua). Regular ancestor acknowledgment includes the pouring of libation before significant meals, before significant decisions, and at regular intervals — particularly at the new moon and on Akwasidae. After death, a person's soul remains in Asamando — the ancestral realm governed by Asase Yaa — where it remains until the family's remembrance fades across generations.

The Adinkra Symbols

A Visual Philosophical Language

The Adinkra symbols are one of the most extraordinary achievements in the Akan tradition — a system of visual symbols, each encoding a specific philosophical principle, proverb, or sacred teaching. The name "Adinkra" comes from the Twi word meaning "to express oneself" or "to say goodbye" — the symbols were originally used on funeral cloth and on items sent as messages.

The Adinkra symbols are a philosophical language, encoding teachings about ethics, the nature of reality, the character of the divine and of the good human life. They appear on Kente cloth, on royal regalia, on pottery and carved wood, on architecture, and on contemporary art and design worldwide. Each symbol is a teaching that can be read, contemplated, and applied.

The Twenty-Eight Major Adinkra Symbols

SANKOFA — "Se wo were fi na wosankofa a yenkyi"

It is not wrong to go back and fetch what you forgot. The Sankofa symbol depicts a bird with its head turned backward while its feet face forward — moving into the future while retrieving something essential from the past. This is the most Haligric of all Adinkra symbols: the entire Haligricity library is a Sankofa act.

GYE NYAME — "Except for God"

The most widely used Adinkra symbol in Ghana today, declaring that Nyame's authority supersedes all human authority and that no force in all of creation operates independently of the divine.

NYAME DUA — "God's tree"

The altar of Nyame — the recognition that the divine is not only in sacred spaces and sacred times but in the center of ordinary life.

SANKOFA BIRD (alternate) — Recovery of Lost Wisdom

A bird with an egg in its mouth while looking backward — the egg represents the sacred potential that was lost and must be retrieved and nurtured back to life.

HYE WO NYE — "That which cannot be burned"

Imperishability and endurance. The Kra (divine spark) cannot be destroyed by any earthly force.

DWENNIMMEN — "Ram's horns"

Humility, strength, and the power of wisdom. The ram is strong enough to fight, humble enough to kneel, wise enough to know when each is appropriate.

AKOMA — "The heart"

Patience, tolerance, and faithfulness. The heart is the seat of moral character in Akan tradition — a person with a good heart (akoma pa) is patient, faithful, tolerant, honest.

AYA — "Fern"

Endurance, defiance, and perseverance. The fern grows in difficult conditions — growth sometimes requires claiming life in places that seem inhospitable.

NYAME NNWU NA MAWU — "God never dies, therefore I cannot die"

Because Nyame is eternal, and because the human Kra is a fragment of Nyame's creative power, the deepest dimension of the human person is also eternal. Death is return, not annihilation.

Additional Adinkra Symbols

HWEMUDUA — "The measuring stick": the importance of clear standards and honest self-assessment.

NYAME BIRIBI WO SORO — "God, there is something in the heavens, let it reach me": the active orientation of hope.

PEMPAMSIE — "Sew to sew": the interlocking chain, teaching the power of unity and cooperation.

FUNTUNFUNEFUDENKYEMFUNEFU — Two crocodiles sharing a stomach: unity in diversity. Despite apparent competition, all members of a community share the same fundamental needs.

FAWOHODIE — Independence, freedom, emancipation: freedom achieved through one's own effort.

NKYINKYIM — Adaptability, dynamism, versatility: the path of wisdom is not always straight.

AKOMA NTOSO — "Linked hearts": understanding and agreement across difference.

MPATAPHO — The knot of pacification: reconciliation, and the recognition that conflict properly resolved creates stronger bonds.

DENKUEM — Crocodile: the ability to live in two worlds without belonging fully to either.

BI NKA BI — "No one should bite another": peaceful coexistence, not using strength to harm.

ESE NE TEKREMA — Teeth and tongue: friends have disagreements but learn to work through them with care for the relationship.

ANANSE NTONTAN — The spider's web: wisdom, creativity, and the complex network of relationships.

MMERE DANE — "Time changes": all things are subject to change; the wisdom of adapting without clinging.

FOFO — Jealousy and envy: the cautionary symbol naming what undermines wisdom.

NKONSONKONSON — Chain link: we are connected to each other, and our connections are our strength.

OSRANE NE NSOROMMA — Crescent moon and star: love, faithfulness, reaching toward each other.

WO NSA DA MU A — "If your hands are in the dish": community requires active engagement, not passive membership.

KRAMO BONE AMMA YANTEAN KRAMO PA — Do not judge an entire tradition by the conduct of its worst representatives.

How to Work with Adinkra Symbols

Complete Practice Guide

CHOOSING YOUR SYMBOL: Sit quietly and review the Adinkra symbols. The symbol that most needs to be worked with will feel either strongly attractive or slightly uncomfortable — both responses are informative.

DRAWING THE SYMBOL: Draw the symbol by hand on clean paper. Spend at least five minutes. The hand-drawn symbol carries more engagement than a printed one.

THE TEACHING CONTEMPLATION: Sit with the drawn symbol and speak the teaching aloud. Sit in silence and let the teaching work on you. Where in your life does this apply right now?

THE DAILY APPLICATION: Throughout the day, return to the symbol's teaching. When facing a decision: "What does Sankofa (or Dwennimmen, or Akoma) say about this situation?"

THE MONTHLY ADINKRA REVIEW: On the new moon each month, choose one symbol whose teaching will guide the month's work. Post it visibly in your space. At the end of the month, journal how this teaching showed up.

Kente Cloth

Sacred Weaving as Philosophy

Kente cloth is the brilliantly colored, geometrically complex woven cloth of the Asante and Ewe peoples of Ghana — among the most recognizable African textile traditions in the world. Kente is not merely a beautiful textile — it is a philosophical statement woven in fiber and color.

Every Kente pattern has a name and a meaning. Gold represents royalty, wealth, and spiritual purity. Green represents growth, renewal, and the natural world. Red represents passion, political power, and the blood of sacrifice. Black represents intensification, spiritual energy, and the wisdom of age. Kente is worn at the most significant occasions. In the contemporary world, Kente has been adopted by African diaspora communities worldwide as a symbol of cultural reclamation — a Sankofa act of reclaiming what the diaspora experience tried to erase.

The Stools

Sacred Authority and Ancestral Power

The stool (adwa) is the primary symbol of authority, sacred power, and ancestral connection in Akan culture. The stool is not a seat — it is the material home of a person's soul (the Kra and Sunsum) and, for rulers, of the entire community's ancestral power.

Every Akan person of significance has a personal stool. When a person dies, their personal stool is blackened with soot and kept in the family's ancestral stool house — becoming the material home of the ancestor's spirit and the focus of ancestral veneration for that specific ancestor.

The Golden Stool (Sika Dwa Kofi)

The Soul of the Asante Nation

The Golden Stool of Asante is among the most sacred objects in all of Africa — the material home of the sunsum (soul) of the entire Asante nation, called down from heaven by Okomfo Anokye in the late 17th century to unite the Asante peoples under the leadership of Osei Tutu.

The Golden Stool has never been sat upon by any human being — not even by the Asantehene. It has its own throne beside the Asantehene's throne. When the British governor demanded to sit on the Golden Stool in 1900 as a demonstration of British sovereignty, the Asante rose in immediate armed revolt — the War of the Golden Stool — led by Yaa Asantewaa, the queen mother of Ejisu. The stool was never captured by the British and remains in Asante today. The Golden Stool stands 18 inches high, 24 inches long, and 12 inches wide, and is made entirely of gold.

Akan Sacred Ritual

Libation and the Ancestors

The pouring of libation (nsa) is the most fundamental and most regularly practiced sacred act in the Akan tradition — the primary technology of maintaining the living relationship between the community of the living and the community of the dead, and the primary means of acknowledging Nyame, the Abosom, and the ancestral community before any significant action.

Libation in the Akan tradition is not symbolic — it is genuinely nourishing. The liquid poured on the ground reaches the ancestors in the invisible world through the earth's mediation, through Asase Yaa. When libation is poured, specific ancestors are called by name, thanked for their continued care, informed of what is happening in the family's life, and asked for specific blessings.

How to Pour Libation

Step by Step

PURPOSE: To acknowledge Nyame, Asase Yaa, the Abosom, and the ancestors before any significant occasion.

WHAT YOU NEED: A vessel of liquid (water, palm wine, or spirits), a clear outdoor space or a space near your ancestor altar.

STEP 1 — HOLD THE VESSEL: Hold the vessel in both hands. Breathe and center. Feel the weight of what you are holding — this is the material form of the connection you are about to affirm.

STEP 2 — CALL NYAME: Pour a small amount: "Nyame, you who never die, I pour this libation in your honor. I thank you for life, for breath, for the gifts you have placed in my keeping. Nyame, hear my words."

STEP 3 — CALL ASASE YAA: Pour again: "Asase Yaa, Mother Earth, you who hold the ancestors in your keeping — I acknowledge your presence beneath every step I take. I pour for you."

STEP 4 — CALL THE ABOSOM: Pour again: "Abosom, spiritual forces of the rivers, the forests, the mountains — I acknowledge your power and your protection. I pour for you."

STEP 5 — CALL THE ANCESTORS: Pour as you call each ancestor by name. If names are unknown: "Nananom Nsamanfo — great ancestors of my lineage — I pour for you. I know your names have been lost to me through the dispersions of history, but I know you exist and I honor you."

STEP 6 — POUR FOR THE OCCASION: State what the libation is for. "I pour this libation as I begin [this ceremony, this meal, this new undertaking, this day]. I ask for your blessings, your guidance, and your protection."

STEP 7 — CLOSE: "So be it. Nyame, Asase Yaa, Abosom, Nsamanfo — I honor you. Medaase."

The Abadinto

Birth and Naming Ceremony

The Abadinto (also called Adinto or Edin Toa — "to throw a name") is the Akan naming and outdoorings ceremony: the ritual that formally introduces a newborn to the community and gives the child their name and identity. It is the first of the four Akan rites of passage — naming, puberty, marriage, and death.

The Akan do not name a child until the child has been alive for seven days. During the first seven days, the child is understood to be in a liminal state — a stranger (ohoho), potentially a spirit who has come only to look at the world and return. Only after surviving seven days is the child considered to have committed to staying in the land of the living. Until that day, no mourning is performed if the child dies.

The ceremony is held on the eighth day — always on the same day of the week as the birth. The child receives their kradin (soul name), which reflects the Akan day of the week on which they were born. In addition, the child receives a second name honoring an elder relative (living or deceased) whose character it is hoped the child will embody, and a family name.

The Ceremony — Step by Step

PREPARATION: Items gathered before the ceremony: gin (nsa), two glass cups, a bottle of water, a mat (kete), a calabash (pakyi or kora), and for a girl — a broom; for a boy — a cutlass.

STEP 1 — BRINGING THE CHILD: Early on the morning of the eighth day, two elders of good character from the father's family come to bring the child and mother from the mother's house to the father's house, where the ceremony is performed.

STEP 2 — FIRST LIBATION: An elder pours the first libation with water, calling on Nyame, Asase Yaa, and the ancestors to bless the gathering and the child.

STEP 3 — TASTING WATER AND SPIRIT: The child is given a small taste of water (teaching clarity and truth — water does not lie) and then a small taste of gin (teaching that life contains bitterness as well as sweetness, and both must be known).

STEP 4 — THE MAT AND THE TOOL: A mat is spread and the child is placed on it naked — a thanksgiving to Asase Yaa for sustaining the child's life. A broom is placed in a girl's hand (covered briefly with a calabash) symbolizing the ethic of care and household stewardship. A cutlass is placed beside a boy, symbolizing the role of provider and protector.

STEP 5 — THE OUTDOORING: The child is formally brought outside for the first time — the "outdoorings." This moment marks the child's entry into the community of the living. Family, friends, and neighbors witness the child's first appearance in the world.

STEP 6 — THE NAMING: The traditional priest or elder announces the child's names — the kradin (soul name from the birth day), the elder's name the child honors, and the family name. The child is addressed by name and told what the family and community expect of them.

STEP 7 — CLOSING LIBATION: A final libation is poured — the outdoorings prayer — asking for blessings for the child's family and requesting that the child be obedient, truthful, and righteous.

STEP 8 — CELEBRATION: Songs of praise are sung. Guests bring gifts. A communal feast with drumming and dancing follows, as the new member of the community is celebrated.

The Festival Calendar and the Sacred Year

The Akan sacred calendar is organized around the 42-day Akan calendar cycle (Aday), each cycle culminating in two major sacred days: Akwasidae (Sunday Aday) and Awukudae (Wednesday Aday). There are nine Aday cycles per Akan year.

Akwasidae

On Akwasidae, the Asantehene and all senior chiefs enter the nkonuafieso (stool house), barefoot and with lowered cloth as signs of humility before the ancestors. They greet each ancestor by name, pour libation, and offer a sheep whose blood is smeared on the ancestral stools. The Akom ritual — dances by the Okomfo — takes place to honor the Abosom and induce spiritual communion. The Akwasidae concludes with a grand durbar where the Asantehene receives his chiefs and subjects in full regalia. The Asantehene may hold Akwasidae wherever he is in the world — in July 2024, he delivered a keynote address at the British Museum on "Asante Culture and Heritage." In 2026, he is expected to observe Akwasidae in Washington DC during a visit for the Millennium Excellence Awards.

Major Festivals

ODWIRA:

The most important Akan festival — a purification and thanksgiving festival held annually after the yam harvest. The Asante Odwira had not been held since 1961; under Asantehene Otumfuo Osei Tutu II, it was revived in October 2025 — a 64-year gap, closed. This historic restoration was described as rekindle of "the great spirits of Asanteman."

HOMOWO:

A harvest festival of the Ga people meaning "to hoot at hunger." Traditional food (kpokpoi, from fermented corn) is shared with both the living and the dead simultaneously.

OHUM:

A river festival honoring the Abosom of major rivers — a purification ceremony for the entire community, including ceremonial bathing and renewal of the covenant with the river's sacred force.

Puberty and Coming-of-Age

Bragoro

The bragoro is the Akan female puberty ceremony — the ritual that marks a girl's transition to womanhood at the time of her first menstruation. It is one of the most important life-cycle rituals in Akan tradition, publicly celebrating the girl's new status.

The bragoro involves: ritual bathing of the new woman in water with sacred herbs, the application of specific clay and oils to her body, the wearing of specific cloth and jewelry marking her new status, the gathering of the women of the community to celebrate and teach her, specific sacred foods and drinks, and the formal public presentation of the new woman to the community.

The theological significance is clear: the onset of menstruation is not a private, medical, or shameful event — it is the most significant physiological threshold in a woman's life, marking her entry into the fullness of her creative power, and it is honored publicly with ceremony and community celebration.

Death and Funerary Practice in Akan Tradition

Death in Akan tradition is a transition — the departure of the Kra back to Nyame, the return of the body to Asase Yaa, and the transformation of the person from a living community member to an ancestor in Asamando. The funerary practices manage this transition carefully and honor the person who has departed.

Akan funerals are communal events of extraordinary elaborateness — lasting multiple days, marked by specific clothing (red and black are traditional mourning colors; white or black-and-white for elderly deaths, symbolizing a life well lived). The One-Week Celebration (Nnawotwe da) is held seven days after death. Wake-keeping involves overnight vigils with music, dancing, and mourning. Funeral day features ritual dirges, specific drumming patterns through the fontomfrom drums, and libation guiding the deceased's transition.

Contemporary Ghana is famous for its fantasy coffins — a carpenter's coffin shaped like a hammer, a fisherman's coffin shaped like a fish. This tradition is a profound theological statement: even in death, the specific personhood of the individual is honored and celebrated.

Akan Healing

Herbalism and Sacred Medicine

Akan healing tradition is one of the most sophisticated ethnobotanical traditions in West Africa — a body of knowledge about the healing properties of specific plants that operates simultaneously on the physical and spiritual dimensions of illness.

Akan healing distinguishes between the Odunsinyi (herbalist, addressing the physical dimension) and the Okomfo (medium/priest, addressing the spiritual dimension). In practice, these roles often overlap — effective treatment must address both, because the Akan understanding of illness recognizes that most significant conditions have both physical and spiritual causes. Contemporary pharmacological research has confirmed genuine medicinal value in many traditional Akan plant preparations, including prekese, nkontomire, and neem tree preparations.

The Okyeame

The Art of Sacred Speech

The Okyeame (royal spokesperson, linguist, or ambassador) is the specialist in sacred speech whose role is to mediate all significant communication between the chief and the public — transforming what the chief says into a form appropriate for public hearing, and what the public says into a form appropriate for royal reception.

The chief never speaks directly to the public in formal settings. The Okyeame receives the chief's words and retransmits them, elaborated, beautified, and contextualized. This is the recognition that significant communication requires a specialized vehicle — that the movement of meaning between different registers of power requires mediation by someone trained in both registers.

The Okyeame carries a distinctive staff (okyeame poma) topped with a gold-covered finial depicting a specific Adinkra symbol — often Sankofa, or a hand with a palm nut. The staff is the Okyeame's emblem of office: the sacred word given visible, portable form.

Akan Proverbs as Sacred Wisdom

The Akan tradition is extraordinary for its proverbs — the ebe are short, precise, often startling statements of wisdom that encode years of collective observation and philosophical reflection in forms that can be memorized, recalled in the moment of need, and transmitted without loss across generations.

"Onipa na ohia onipa"

It is a person who needs a person — the fundamental teaching of interdependence. No one is self-sufficient.

"Obi nkyere akwadaa Nyame"

No one teaches a child about God — knowledge of the divine is innate. Every person already knows something of Nyame from within.

"Tiri mu nsem na eye den"

The matters of the head are difficult — what happens in a person's inner life (in their Kra and Sunsum) is more complex and more determining than external circumstances.

"Yaanom na ye nim de akodi"

We are the ones who know how to carry difficulty — the community has survived hardship before and has the resources to survive again.

"Se wo were fi na wosankofa a, yenkyi"

It is not wrong to go back and fetch what you forgot — the Sankofa teaching in its original proverb form.

Akan Tradition Today

The Akan tradition is vigorously alive in contemporary Ghana. The Asante Kingdom, headed by Asantehene Otumfuo Osei Tutu II (the 16th Asantehene, enthroned April 26, 1999), remains a functioning institution with significant cultural, social, and in some domains political authority. The festivals — the Odwira, the royal durbars, the Akwasidae ceremonies — are still performed, drawing tens of thousands of participants.

The Adinkra symbols have achieved remarkable global spread — appearing on the architecture of the African Union headquarters, on jewelry and textiles sold worldwide, on academic regalia at African universities, and on the walls of African American cultural institutions across the United States. The Sankofa symbol in particular has been widely adopted in the African diaspora as a symbol of cultural reclamation.

At the same time, Christian evangelicalism is the majority religion in Ghana today, and many elements of traditional Akan practice have been challenged or suppressed within Christian communities. Christian denominations have historically demanded that Akan converts reject the Black Stool, ancestors, and all ancestral activities as conditions of membership. The Okomfo tradition is under particular pressure — the same tension between independent sacred authority and institutional religious control that has challenged shamanic practitioners wherever institutional religion has become dominant.

Repatriation and the Return of the Sacred

One of the most significant recent developments in Akan tradition has been the ongoing return of sacred royal artifacts looted during the colonial period — a process of extraordinary spiritual and historical weight for the Asante Kingdom.

On February 5-8, 2024 — the 150th anniversary of the 1874 British sacking of Kumasi — the Fowler Museum at the University of California Los Angeles permanently returned seven royal artifacts to Asantehene Otumfuo Osei Tutu II at the Manhyia Palace Museum. The returned items included the sika mena (elephant tail whisk), two gold stool ornaments, a gold necklace, two bracelets, and an ornamental asipim chair. The Asantehene declared that repatriation "signifies the return of our souls." Negotiator Kwasi Ampene echoed the spirit of the occasion.

In April-May 2024, the British Museum and the Victoria & Albert Museum returned 32 gold and silver treasures on a six-year loan (the National Heritage Act of 1963 prevents UK museums from permanently deaccessioning their collections). The returned items include a 300-year-old Mponponso sword used in swearing-in ceremonies, a gold peace pipe, and gold discs worn by officials responsible for cleansing the king's soul. Over 130 artifacts were returned in 2024 alone, with South Africa's AngloGold Ashanti, Switzerland's Barbier-Mueller Museum, and others also participating. The Netherlands and Germany have pledged the return of approximately 2,000 additional artifacts.

The Asante Odwira festival — not held since 1961 — was revived in October 2025 under Otumfuo Osei Tutu II, marking a historic 64-year gap closed. The Odwira is the most comprehensive expression of Akan sacred life: purification, thanksgiving, and ancestral renewal. Its restoration was an act of profound cultural reaffirmation.

Haligricity Convergences

Sankofa — The Most Haligric Teaching

The Sankofa principle — it is not wrong to go back and fetch what you forgot — is perhaps the single concept in any tradition that most directly names what Haligricity is doing. Every deep dive in this library is a Sankofa act. The entire Haligricity Research Integration Series is a Sankofa library — a systematic reclamation of what the dominant narrative of Western civilization tried to make us forget. The Akan named this practice two thousand years before Haligricity was conceived. Sankofa.

The Soul Anatomy and the Tetrality

The Akan soul anatomy — Kra (divine spark), Sunsum (personal spirit), Mogya (blood/matrilineal heritage), Ntoro (spiritual essence from the father) — provides the West African philosophical confirmation of what the Haligric Tetrality holds about the human being as a multidimensional reality. The Kra corresponds to the practitioner's deepest divine nature. The Sunsum corresponds to the Feeling dimension. Mogya and Ntoro point toward the complex of inheritance that the practitioner works with and within.

The Abadinto and Sacred Belonging

The Akan naming ceremony's understanding — that a child is not yet fully part of the community until they have committed to staying, until the seven days of liminal waiting are complete, until the formal naming integrates them into the social fabric — is the Akan articulation of what Haligricity holds about genuine belonging: it must be earned through presence, confirmed through commitment, and celebrated through community witness.

Libation and the Ancestor Altar

The Akan libation practice — calling ancestors by name, thanking them for their continued care, informing them of the family's situation, and asking for specific blessings — is the most complete model in any West African tradition of the Haligric ancestor altar practice. The relationship with the ancestors is not a special practice for special occasions — it is the ongoing, daily foundation of sacred life.

The Okyeame and Haligric Sacred Speech

The Okyeame institution — the specialist in sacred speech who transforms raw communication into its most appropriate, most beautiful, most effective form — is the Akan articulation of what Haligricity holds about the Speaking dimension of the Tetrality. Sacred speech is not merely sincere expression. It is skilled craft in the service of truth.

*"Se wo were fi na wosankofa a, yenkyi.
It is not wrong to go back and fetch what you forgot."*

— Akan proverb (the Sankofa teaching)

The bird looks backward while moving forward. The wisdom that was forgotten does not cease to exist — it waits, patient, for the one who will return to claim it. The Adinkra symbols are still speaking. The libation is still nourishing the ancestors. The Kra that Nyame placed within each person at birth is still present, still the same divine spark it was on the first day — waiting for the practices that will allow it to be recognized, honored, and expressed in its fullness. Sankofa. Go back and fetch it. Grand Rising.